



ASPIRING INDIA

[By Kaveree Bamzai]

The mind is the most powerful tool. It multiplies your efforts." So says 18-year-old Menka Kumari, a medical aspirant who is one of many who huddle together in the Curzon reading room of the Khuda Bakhsh Oriental Public Library in Patna. Indeed in the age of Google, it is an irony that musty, 105-year-old libraries still power the dreams of young people on the cusp of a new decade. An iron will still substitute for inherited advantages of geography or history. But it's typical of India, a country where the exhibitionists of *Emotional Atyachar* co-exist with the aspirationalists of small-town India. Where there is place for the independent rock of the all-girl Shillong band Afflatus as well as the Bollywood dreams of Rajni Kant, a 21-year-old aspiring actor in a Chandigarh school. Where a trainee pilot who has taken a loan of Rs 20 lakh can worry about getting a job in a recession-hit sector as much as a young man in Thrissur can borrow a Nokia 6233 to make a movie.

This is the young India, daring to dream, in a nation more assured of its economy, its place at the global high table, even its imperfect democracy. It's the youngsters INDIA TODAY correspondents set out to map in their habitat. A dance class in Jaipur that has become a factory for reality TV contestants. A pre-medical coaching class in Bhopal. An FM station in Chennai. The stories were of grit and gumption. Of two engineers in Srinagar who have vowed not to let destiny get in the way of their digital dreams. Of a young man from Parsauni who travels 45 km every day to Gorakhpur, first on cycle and then on an overloaded auto to learn English, a language he believes is his ticket to success. Of a perky 17-year-old boxer from Wangjing in Manipur who is learning to let her fists fly. It's a generation

65%
of the total
population
is under 35



Dreams for a NEW DECADE